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'THE WEAKEST LINK IN THE IMPERIAL CHAIN'

Britain and the South African war
of 1899–1902

BACKGROUND NARRATIVE

Nineteenth-century South African history was shaped by continual tension between the Dutch-speaking Boer or Afrikaner settlers, whose ancestors had arrived in the 1650s, and the more recently established British presence at the Cape. The Boers' determination to preserve their distinctive identity led them to undertake the 'Great Trek' into the interior in 1835–7. The settlements established by these trekkers were to be known as the Transvaal and the Orange Free State. Here the Boers nurtured their way of life, based upon pastoral farming, an austere Old Testament religion, a preference for republican government and the denial of political rights to the native black population. Their sense of nationalism developed in reaction to British attempts to incorporate the Transvaal in a South African federation in 1877. A brief military confrontation in 1880–1, known as the first Anglo-Boer War, culminated in a British defeat at Majuba Hill. This was followed by the restoration of the Transvaal's independence, subject to British oversight of its foreign policy, in the Pretoria Convention of 1881. Although this unusual arrangement was confirmed by the London Convention three years later, it remained a standing affront to Boer nationalists led by the Transvaal's

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fiercely independent President, Paul Kruger. From an opposite perspective, it was also viewed as an unhappy compromise by imperial-minded Britons. They sought full imperial control over the whole of Southern Africa.

In 1886 the discovery of gold in the Witwatersrand, an area of the Transvaal, transformed the economic potential of the Boer republic, enabling it to challenge the historic predominance of Cape Colony. In the next decade, the completion of the Delagoa Bay railway linked the Transvaal with the port of Lourenço Marques in Portuguese East Africa. This freed Kruger's regime from its dependence on British-held Cape Town for access to the sea. The gold rush drew in thousands of mainly British prospectors known as the 'uitlanders', who sought to make their fortune around the mining town of Johannesburg.

Fearing that they would be outnumbered by the newcomers, the Boers not only retained a monopoly of key materials such as dynamite but denied the uitlanders voting rights until they had been resident for fourteen years. In December 1895 Cecil Rhodes, Prime Minister of Cape Colony and chairman of the British South Africa Company, tried to wrest control of the Transvaal from the Boers by means of a settler uprising. In London, Joseph Chamberlain, Colonial Secretary in Lord Salisbury's government, gave covert and uncommitted support to the project. Although keen to undermine Boer political power, Chamberlain did not want to see an independent uitlander republic which might be no more friendly to imperial interests than the Kruger regime. In the event the rising failed to materialise and a foolhardy raid led by Rhodes' associate, Dr Leander Starr Jameson, ended in humiliation. Although Chamberlain's reputation survived the subsequent inquiry, the raid destroyed Rhodes' credibility and handed the Boers an unexpected propaganda success. It also won for the Transvaal the moral support of the Orange Free State and of Cape Colony's Dutch-speaking population, together with wider European sympathy.

In 1897 the arrival in Cape Colony of a new High Commissioner, Sir Alfred Milner, heralded a new and more assertive phase in imperial policy. Milner viewed South Africa as 'the weakest link in the imperial chain'¹ and was prepared to confront Kruger's government in order to secure British paramountcy. In particular

he sought to present the political grievances of the uitlanders as a justification for imperial intervention. The killing of a British settler on the Rand, Tom Edgar, by a Boer policeman in December 1898 was magnified into a symbol of Transvaal government oppression. In a famous despatch to Chamberlain in April 1899, intended for publication, Milner melodramatically compared the settlers' lot to that of the 'helots', a class of slave in ancient Greece. At the end of May he met Kruger at Bloemfontein, capital of the Orange Free State. Kruger offered to halve the residential qualification for the uitlander franchise. Notwithstanding Chamberlain's advice that he should continue to negotiate, Milner was unaccommodating. The conference broke down on his insistence that the Boers should grant a five-year franchise qualification with immediate effect and that the Rand should receive a form of self-government. The Boer leader interpreted these demands as a bid for political domination: 'it is our country you want'. The Transvaal continued to build up its military forces and Milner requested reinforcements for the ten thousand British troops already in South Africa.

In August Kruger declared his readiness to accept the franchise conditions demanded at Bloemfontein. The offer was, however, qualified in two ways. Britain must abandon her claim to overlordship and promise not to intervene in future on behalf of the settlers. In a speech later that month Chamberlain declared that Kruger 'dribbles out reforms like water from a squeezed sponge . . . The sands are running down in the glass.'² The assumption was that Kruger was playing for time and was not sincerely interested in a settlement favourable to uitlander and imperial interests. In September Britain decided to reinforce the garrison in Natal. In order to exploit the advantage of their current numerical superiority, the Transvaal and Orange Free State mobilised their forces. By October Chamberlain was preparing to issue an ultimatum when Kruger presented his own demand for the withdrawal of British forces. Shortly afterwards the Boer armies invaded Natal. The second Anglo-Boer War, often known as the South African War, had begun.

After severe initial reverses the British annexed the Boer republics in 1900. The Boers proved resourceful, however, in staving off final defeat by means of guerrilla tactics. British forces under

Field Marshal Roberts and General Kitchener resorted to the confinement of Boer women and children in concentration camps, a morally questionable tactic designed to deprive the enemy of their civilian support system. Peace was signed at Vereeniging in May 1902. Victory had been achieved at a terrible cost in terms of civilian lives and of consequent damage to Britain's international reputation.

In 1906–7 a new Liberal administration in Britain took the first steps towards the pacification of the Boer peoples by granting responsible government to the Transvaal and the Orange Free State. By 1910 both British and Boer leaders, for different reasons, had reached the conclusion that their interests would be best served by combining the various territories of Southern Africa into one unit. The outcome was the Union of South Africa, which joined Canada, Australia and New Zealand as a self-governing dominion within the British Empire.

ANALYSIS: HOW DID BRITAIN BECOME INVOLVED IN WAR IN SOUTH AFRICA IN 1899?

The Anglo-Boer War of 1899–1902 continues to attract historians' attention as a crucial test of Britain's imperial role. It is important not only for its impact upon Southern Africa but for the way in which its prolongation led to a widespread questioning of British institutions and national fibre. The conflict taught the imperial power, in Rudyard Kipling's famous phrase, 'no end of a lesson'. The arguments over 'national efficiency' which coloured Edwardian political debate were stimulated by failure to overcome Boer resistance rapidly and at low cost. In areas as diverse as defence planning, working-class health and social reform, the war helped to set the domestic agenda for the opening years of the new century.

Historians are at one in the importance that they attach to the war. Its origins, however, continue to be hotly debated. For example, scholars have begun tracing the beginning of their analysis from very different points in time. J.S. Marais' classic work began with the discovery of gold in 1886. Andrew Porter's study focuses on the diplomatic and political events of 1895–9, the first four years of Joseph Chamberlain's Colonial Secretaryship. More recently, Iain Smith has located the decisive turning point in the renewed assertion of British interests in the 1870s.³

The issue of dating is related to a deeper controversy between holders of opposing ideological positions. Early interpretations, by commentators sympathetic to the British side, saw the Boers as an obstructive force in the path of the imperial power's 'civilising mission'. They endorsed Alfred Milner's description of the conflict as an inevitable clash of opposing cultures: 'two wholly antagonistic systems – a medieval race oligarchy and a modern industrial state . . . cannot live permanently side by side in what is after all one country'.⁴ A glance at the index of Cecil Headlam's carefully selected edition of Milner's papers reveals this kind of bias. The entries for the Transvaal include the following: 'despotic oligarchy of', 'unprogressiveness of', 'Government's policy a curse to South Africa'.⁵

Among those who favour explanations based upon the role of impersonal forces, the most influential have been advocates of an economic interpretation. J.A. Hobson placed the ambitions of the gold-mining magnates, the so-called Randlords, at the centre of his analysis. He linked the Jameson raid and the outbreak of war in a conspiracy organised by 'a small confederacy of international mine owners and speculators' determined 'to secure for the mines a cheap supply of adequate labour'.⁶ Hobson's emphasis on the importance of minerals has been endorsed, from a Marxist perspective, by a number of later historians. Writing in the 1970s, Shula Marks and Stanley Trapido argued that the annexation of the Transvaal was motivated by a need to secure gold supplies for the British economy and to protect the interests of the mining industry.⁷ The overthrow of Kruger's regime would satisfy the needs of the magnates. It would also ensure British control of the region's gold reserves at a time when shortages of this metal, so vital to Britain's international trading position, were anticipated. From a non-Marxist perspective, P.J. Cain and A.G. Hopkins have fitted Southern Africa into their thesis of 'gentlemanly capitalism', arguing that growing British investment there explains the urge to imperial expansion in the late nineteenth century.⁸

Economic interpretations continue to attract widespread support. Nigel Worden's 1994 synthesis of work on modern South African history stresses the political role of deep-level mining interests.⁹ High production costs made these interests dependent on the recruitment of cheap, unskilled African labour and on favourable government policy. Frustrated by Transvaal taxes and monopolies, and denied the chance of exerting influence within the Afrikaner political system, the mine owners sought external aid. Their objective was a change of government that would protect their long-term interests in the Rand.

There are, however, problems with interpretations that ascribe such a major role to the magnates and to gold. Whereas it is easy to connect the Randlords to the Jameson raid, there is little evidence to support claims that they directly affected the decision for war. Indeed, it seems that the debacle of 1895-6 caused many senior figures in the mining houses to draw back from a damaging confrontation with the Transvaal authorities. As the research of Iain Smith and others has demonstrated, the Randlords' preference in 1899 was for a negotiated settlement.¹⁰ Their work also underlines the lack of concrete evidence of links between British officialdom and mining or financial interests. Britain had no need to secure physical control over the gold of the Transvaal, and this was not the outcome of the war.¹¹ It has simply not been proved that the minds of the key decision makers in 1899 were focused on gold as a commodity in the international economy.

If the economic interpretation of the war is not fully satisfactory, does the answer lie in the political field, in the actions of the leading figures in Whitehall and the Cape? Thomas Pakenham, author of the standard narrative history of the war, is one of several historians to focus heavily on the relationship between Joseph Chamberlain in the Colonial Office and Sir Alfred Milner, Britain's 'man on the spot'. Milner is portrayed as a man driven by a sense of imperial mission, determined to annex the Boer republics and to integrate them into a wider federation of the white empire. Whereas Chamberlain sought to bring the Boers to conclude a settlement favourable to British interests, Milner's preference was for a straightforward takeover. The latter used his contacts in the British establishment to influence the Colonial Secretary, and deliberately limited the scope for compromise in his dealings with the Boer leaders. According to Pakenham, this was 'Milner's war', a conflict whose origins can be traced in essence to the inflexibility of a powerful proconsul.¹²

It is important, however, not to see these individuals as acting in isolation from wider political processes. To suggest that Milner dragged Chamberlain, and Chamberlain dragged a reluctant British government into war, requires a selective reading of correspondence from the period. As Ronald Hyam reminds us, this was a conflict of states, not of individuals.¹³ Andrew Porter's research into the political background of the war has shown that Chamberlain enjoyed the steady support of the cabinet as a whole.¹⁴ Although ministers expected Kruger to climb down without the need for war, the military option was contemplated from 1895 onwards. Salisbury and his senior colleagues were reluctant to incur the costs of overseas war, yet did not shrink from this when persuaded of its necessity. The Prime Minister was

reported by a senior civil servant in October 1899 as 'prepared to face war sooner than not get out of Kruger terms that will secure good government at Johannesburg and make the Boers feel that we are and must be the paramount power in South Africa'.¹⁵ Salisbury remained consistent in his defence of a forward policy, responding to critics of harsh British wartime methods that 'the Boers should have thought of [the war's] horrible significance when they invaded the Queen's dominions without a cause'.¹⁶

What, then, were the overriding interests that drove the imperial power to war? According to Robinson and Gallagher, the dominant factor was alarm at the challenge to traditional British predominance presented by an increasingly self-confident Afrikaner power. They explained the prominence given to uitlander political rights in the Transvaal in terms of Britain's need to nurture a community of local 'collaborators' to counterbalance Boer nationalism and uphold British influence.¹⁷ This interpretation has been criticised by Andrew Porter, who has argued that Britain did not see the settlers as effective or trustworthy allies. The real significance of the uitlander franchise lay in the issue's 'democratic' resonance in late Victorian Britain. This gave it the status of a just cause, in whose interest British public sympathy and support could be enlisted.¹⁸

In both the public and the private statements of British ministers and officials, the position of the uitlanders was presented as a means to a larger end. Thus in a letter to Lord Selborne, the junior minister at the Colonial Office in July 1899, Milner noted that 'franchise and every other question have merged in one big issue; is British paramountcy to be vindicated or let slide?'¹⁹ The need to uphold political predominance in the region was underlined by German penetration of Southern Africa in the 1890s. The Cape route to the East remained vital. Nor, for the sake of her prestige as a world power, could Britain allow herself to be defied by Boer intransigence. As Chamberlain expressed it in addressing the House of Commons, 'what is now at stake is the position of Great Britain in South Africa – and with it the estimate formed of our power and influence in our Colonies and throughout the world'.²⁰

In explaining the centrality of Southern Africa to Britain's global strategy, several recent historians try to integrate political and economic factors. Andrew Porter, Iain Smith and others acknowledge the importance of mineral discoveries in transforming the economic potential of the Transvaal. Britain did not go to war to win control of the gold mines, but to prevent the Transvaal from using its newly found wealth to oust Britain as the dominant regional power. The cabinet's

deliberations were shaped not by a wish to protect overseas investments, but by a need, in Salisbury's words, to demonstrate 'that we not the Dutch are Boss'. The growing assertiveness of Kruger's regime in the 1890s undermined the historic assumption of British policy makers, that Cape Colony would always be the centre of gravity in Southern Africa. Although Britain did not necessarily seek annexation of the Transvaal from the outset, the Boer republic certainly could not be permitted to draw the rest of the region away from traditional British influence. If war was necessary in order to re-establish that influence, then the imperial power was prepared to undertake it.

Questions

1. 'Milner's war'. Is there any validity in this description of the South African War of 1899–1902?
2. How would you distinguish between long- and short-term causes of the South African War of 1899–1902?

SOURCES

1. ANGLO-BOER RELATIONS 1895–8

Source A: Lord Salisbury discusses the Transvaal in a letter to Joseph Chamberlain, 30 December 1895.

It is evident sooner or later that State must be mainly governed by Englishmen: though we cannot yet precisely discern what their relations to the British Crown or Cape Colony will be . . . but still it would be better if the revolution which transfers the Transvaal to British rulers were entirely the result of the action of internal forces, and not of Cecil Rhodes' intervention, or of ours.

Source B: Alfred Milner discusses the Dutch-speaking population of Cape Colony in his Graaff Reinet speech, 3 March 1898.

They loathe, very naturally and rightly, the idea of war, and they think that if they can only impress upon the British Government that in case of war with the Transvaal it would have a great number of its own subjects at least in sympathy against it, that is a way to prevent such a calamity. But in this they are totally wrong, for this policy rests on the assumption that Great Britain has some occult design on the independence of the Transvaal – that independence which it has itself given – and that it is seeking cases of quarrel in order to take that independence away . . . So far from seeking cases of quarrel it is the constant

desire of the British Government to avoid causes of quarrel, and not to take up lightly the complaints – and they are numerous – which reach it from British subjects within the Transvaal, for the very reason that it wishes to avoid even the semblance of interference in the internal affairs of that country . . . That is Great Britain's moderate attitude, and she cannot be frightened out of it.

Source C: from a record made by Jan Christian Smuts, the Transvaal's Attorney-General, of a meeting with a British representative, J.G. Fraser, 23 December 1898.

He [Fraser] said that the British Government had now sat still for two years because her own officials had put her in a false position in the Jameson Raid. The time had now however come for her to take action. I asked him what he meant. He said that Gladstone had made a great mistake in giving the country back after Majuba before having defeated the Boers. The Boers throughout South Africa had a vague aspiration for a great republic throughout South Africa and that Gladstone had by his action encouraged this aspiration in them . . . She [the South African Republic] would have nothing to do with the paramount influence of England but had always tried to play a role among the nations and had with a view to that always coquetted with the European powers. In his opinion the time had come to make an end of all this by showing the Boers that England is master in South Africa. I asked him what would give occasion for this. He said that England was very dissatisfied about the mal-administration and especially about ill-treatment of her subjects which was worse here than elsewhere. On this point England would take action.

Questions

1. Explain the references to (a) 'Cecil Rhodes' (Source A) and (b) 'Majuba' (Source C). [4]
- *2. What does Source A reveal of its author's attitude towards British imperial policy making? [4]
3. How persuasive is Source B as a defence of Britain's South African policy at this time? [4]
4. Compare Sources B and C as evidence for the study of Anglo-Boer relations in this period. [6]
5. Using Sources A to C and your own knowledge, how far would you agree that responsibility for the deterioration of Anglo-Boer relations in this period was evenly divided between the two sides? [7]

Worked answer

*2. This source reveals Lord Salisbury, the British Prime Minister, as the advocate of a well-established, pragmatic approach to the extension of imperial influence and authority. He demonstrates flexibility regarding the exact nature of Britain's future relationship with the Transvaal, while making it clear that he wishes to see Britain emerge as the predominant power there. He also expresses a hope that 'internal forces' will act as the indirect agent of British policy in the region. An uprising by settlers on the Transvaal's gold fields would spare Britain the cost, in terms of both money and image, of direct intervention. Within days, the ignominious collapse of Dr Jameson's raid on the Transvaal, and the failure of the settler population to rise in revolt, would disappoint Salisbury's hopes.

SOURCES

2. THE APPROACH OF WAR, 1899

Source D: Alfred Milner writes to Joseph Chamberlain after the Bloemfontein Conference, 14 June 1899.

My proposals for a settlement of the Uitlander grievances on the basis of a moderate measure of enfranchisement having been rejected by the President, and a totally inadequate scheme put forward in their place, he now comes forward with an arbitration proposal. My contention is that the atmosphere in which that or any other concession to the S.A.R. [South African Republic or Transvaal] can be considered has yet to be created. Redress of the grievances of H.M. [Her Majesty's] subjects in the S.A.R. stands at the head of the programme, and nothing else can be considered till that matter is out of the way. I cannot see the smallest reason why H.M. Government should not at once reject this particular proposal, and I advise that this course should be adopted.

Source E: Sir Henry Campbell-Bannerman, leader of the British Liberal Party, addresses the House of Commons, 18 July 1899.

[H]e could see no ground for surprise at the stubborn resistance made by the burghers, and especially by President Kruger, to the proposal to admit Outlanders [uitlanders] to the franchise... the Boers had 'trekked' into the Transvaal to live by themselves, and now they felt themselves swamped by the newcomers, however much it increased their prosperity. Then there was the Jameson raid, which the Boers could not forget... There was a certain strangeness in the idea

that we should go to war to enable our fellow-citizens to give up their own citizenship in favour of another . . . at present there was no case, even for a threat . . . of war.

Source F: the government of the South African Republic states its terms, 16 August 1899.

The Government of the South African Republic . . . will assume that Her Majesty's Government will agree that a precedent shall not be formed by their intervention for similar action in the future, and that no future interference in the internal affairs of the Republic will take place contrary to the Convention. Further that Her Majesty's Government will not insist further upon the assertion of suzerainty, the controversy on this subject being tacitly allowed to drop.

Questions

1. Explain the references to the following: 'Uitlander' (Source D); 'the President' (Source D) and 'suzerainty' (Source F). [3]
2. What light does Source D shed on the reasons for the development of Anglo-Boer hostility? [5]
3. How reliable a picture of relations between Britain and the Transvaal would you expect Source E to provide? [5]
4. How do events in South African history after 1880 help to explain the demands made by the authors of Source F? [5]
- *5. How complete a picture do these sources give of the reasons for the breakdown of Anglo-Boer relations in 1899? [7]

Worked answer

*5. [This question requires you to take a critical overview of all the sources, paying attention to what they omit as well as what they reveal.]

Sources D to F all suggest the important part played by the issue of uitlander political rights in the build up to the Anglo-Boer War. They do not, however, enable the reader to gain an objective view of the merits of the uitlander case or the extent to which it was manipulated for other ends. The only witness here to the crucial Bloemfontein Conference of May 1899 is Milner, who is seen by many historians as pursuing a deliberately provocative policy of his own. We are not given Chamberlain's reply and so have no way of telling how far Milner diverged from the preferred line of his political masters in London. Following the work of A.N. Porter and others, historians increasingly stress the importance of the British cabinet as a whole in the making of

policy. The emphasis in Source D on the personal contacts between particular individuals hardly does justice to this perspective. The deeper issues at stake for Britain – of strategy, economic interest and great power status – are not reflected fully in this selection of sources. Moreover, although Source E is sympathetic to the Boer point of view, we are not given directly the attitude of Kruger and his advisers to the conference. Source F does not justify its claims with detailed reference to the immediate history of Anglo-Boer relations. An unrepresentative selection of diplomatic exchanges and partisan comments, divorced from the wider political context, cannot hope to give more than a limited view of a complex reality.